AHAB
and the
WHALE

The suit you lead is the wind that blows.



2 players | 10+ | 10 min a game

Captain Ahab has the white whale in sight at last. One of you is Ahab, closing in with the harpoons. The other is the Whale, running for the open sea. Neither of you commands the wind. The cards do.

COMPONENTS



North star | East sun | South cross | West moon

- **36 wind cards**: four winds, numbered 1 to 9 in each.
- **1 sea chart**, **1 whale** and **2 player aids**.

HOW IT WORKS

Ahab and the Whale is a trick-taking game for two. The cards you play move one whale across a sea chart.

EVERY CARD IS A WIND

The wind of the **led card** picks the line the whale moves along: North and South, or East and West.

The **trick** picks which way along that line it goes. So sometimes you will want to lose a trick.

TWO GOALS

Ahab wants the whale in **harpoon range** when the hand ends. **The Whale** wants it out on the **open sea**.



The sea chart. The outer ring of 24 cells is the **open sea**. The darker 5×5 inside it is **harpoon range**. Each edge shows its wind: the North star, the East sun, the Southern Cross and the West moon.

SETUP

1. **Place the whale** on the centre cell of the sea chart, the one with the whaleboat.
2. **Choose roles.** One player is Ahab, the other is the Whale. Each takes a player aid.
3. **Deal.** Shuffle the 36 cards and deal 12 to each player. Put the last 12 aside face down without looking at them. They are not used this game.
4. **Choose the first leader** at random.

PLAYING A TRICK

A hand is **12 tricks**. The leader plays any card face up. Its wind is the **wind of the trick**. Then:

1. Follow

The other player must play a card of the led wind if they can. If they can't, they play any card. There are no trumps.

2. Win

If the follower played the led wind, the **higher number** wins. If they couldn't, the **leader** wins.

3. Move the whale

Move the whale **one step**:

What happened	The whale moves
The **leader** won, and the follower followed	in the direction of the led wind
The **follower** won	the **opposite** way to the led wind
The follower couldn't follow (**drift**)	in the direction of the wind the follower played

4. Next trick

Set both cards aside. The winner leads the next trick.

DRIFT

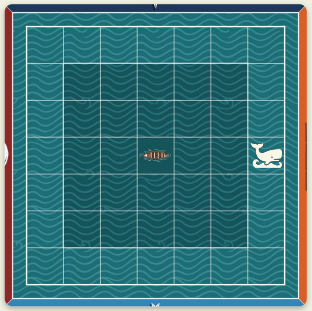
When the follower can't follow, the leader still wins the trick and leads next. But the follower steers: the whale moves the way of the wind they discarded.

AT THE EDGE OF THE CHART

If a step would take the whale off the chart, it stays where it is.

The whale may sit on the open sea during the hand, and it can be pulled back in. Only where it is after the 12th trick counts.

EXAMPLE: THE EDGE

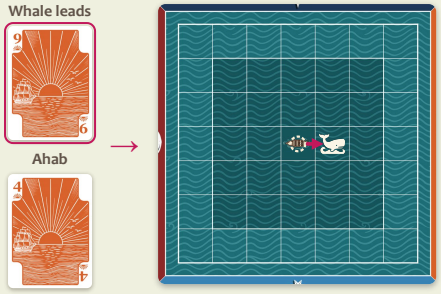


The whale is on the East edge of the open sea. A step East would take it off the chart, so it stays put. A step West brings it back into harpoon range.

PLAYING WITH A STANDARD DECK

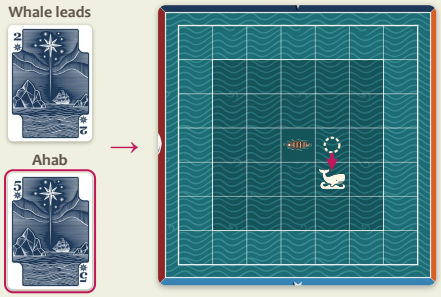
Use the Ace to 9 of each suit: ♠ North, ♥ East, ♦ South, ♣ West. An Ace counts as 1. Draw a 7×7 grid and use a coin for the whale.

EXAMPLE: THE FIRST TRICK



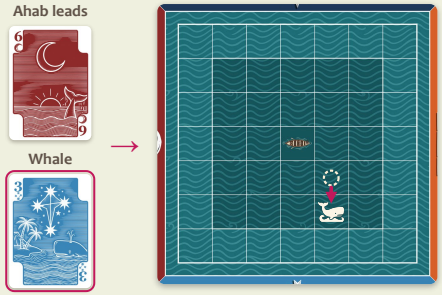
The whale starts on the centre cell. The Whale leads East 9. Ahab follows with East 4. The leader wins, so the whale moves one step **East**. The Whale leads next.

EXAMPLE: THE FOLLOWER WINS



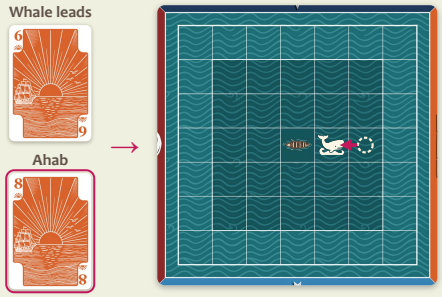
The Whale leads North 2. Ahab must follow, and plays North 5. The follower wins, so the whale moves the opposite way: **South**. Ahab leads next.

EXAMPLE: DRIFT



Ahab leads West 6. The Whale has no West cards and plays South 3. Ahab wins and leads next, but the whale **drifts** one step South, the way of the Whale's card.

EXAMPLE: WIN OR LOSE?



Late in a hand, the whale is one step from the East edge. The Whale leads East 6. Ahab holds East 2 and East 8. If he plays the 2, the leader wins and the whale moves East, onto the open sea. So he plays the 8: he wins, and the whale moves **West**, back towards the centre.

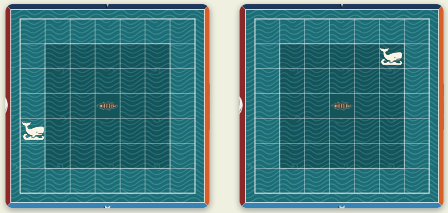
END OF THE HAND

After the **12th trick**, look at the whale:

- **On the open sea:** the Whale wins.
- **In harpoon range:** Ahab wins.

A game is one hand.

EXAMPLE: AFTER THE 12TH TRICK



On the open sea: **the Whale wins**.

At the edge of harpoon range: **Ahab wins**.

Where the whale went during the hand doesn't matter. It may have touched the open sea several times.

PLAYING A MATCH

Play **two games**, swapping roles. The player who did not lead first in the first game leads first in the second.

Win both games to win the match. One game each is a draw.

VARIANT: THE LONG VOYAGE

A longer game. All the rules above apply, with these changes:

- **Sea chart:** a 9×9 grid. The outer ring is the open sea; every cell inside it is harpoon range.
- **The wind never blows twice.** You may not lead the wind that was led on the previous trick, unless every card in your hand is that wind. Leave the last led card face up beside the chart as a reminder.
- **Up to three hands.** Before each hand, shuffle, deal 12 cards each and return the whale to the centre. Players take turns to lead the first trick of each hand.
- **End of a hand:** if the whale is on the open sea, the Whale wins the game at once. Otherwise Ahab scores the hand. Ahab wins the game when he scores his second hand.

ABOUT THE HUNT

In Herman Melville's 1851 novel, Captain Ahab has lost a leg to a great white whale, and he drives his ship and crew around the world to hunt it down. The chart's four winds are a sailor's guides: the North Star, the rising sun in the East, the Southern Cross and the setting moon in the West.

Game design: Dean Morris · Wombat Game Factory
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